# Mark Tobey and the "Two Powers"

BY JULIE OEMING BADIEE

MARK TOBEY is best known to the twentieth century as a painter of great originality who occupies a special place in modern art. Born in 1890 in Centerville, Wisconsin, Tobey's career spanned the period in which American art moved from a rather timid provinciality to a position of world dominance. Tobey began his career as a commercial artist in New York about 1912, but he preferred to live and work in Europe or in the American Northwest. During the 1930s Tobey was a visiting artist at Dartington Hall, a progressive school for the arts in Devonshire, England; he also taught at the Cornish School in Seattle. Tobey is often acknowledged as the foremost painter of the "Northwest School," a group including Morris Graves and Kenneth Callahan, centered around Seattle that explored mystic themes and was particularly interested in uniting Eastern and Western modes of expression.[1] Tobey is best known for his "white writing," an energetic derivation of the techniques of Eastern calligraphy, including Arabic, Chinese, and Japanese forms. Critical events in the development of Tobey's style include his acceptance of the Bahá'í Faith about 1918 and a stay in a Zen monastery in Japan in 1934. Tobey's career reached a high point in Europe in 1958 when he was awarded First Place at the Venice Biennale, the first American painter since Whistler to win such an award. He was also invited to give a retrospective of his work at the Musée des arts décoratifs at the Louvre, an honor never before given a living American artist.[2]

Tobey was recognized and appreciated in Europe to a greater degree than he was in the United States. His delicate, small-sized paintings with their sometimes overt religious imagery ran against the tide of the huge heroic murals of the Abstract Expressionists that dominated the New York School of Abstract Expressionists in the 1950s. In 1962, in a belated recognition of his importance, Tobey was given a retrospective at the Museum of Modern Art in New York, and in 1974 his paintings were the subject of a large show at the National Collection of Fine Arts at the Smithsonian in Washington, D.C. After his death in 1976 Tobey's paintings continued to be recognized as in a recent exhibit of his "City Paintings" in the East Wing of the National Gallery of Art in 1984 and a growing number of publications analyzing his art.[3]

Although Tobey's contribution to modern art is now widely recognized, and his paintings are routinely included in surveys of the great masters of the twentieth century, Tobey had a second life commitment beyond that

Opposite page: Self-portrait by Mark Tobey

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1. Martha Kingsbury, *Northwest Traditions* (Seattle: Seattle Art Museum, 1978) 47–61.

2. *Mark Tobey: Retrospective* (Paris: Musée des arts décoratifs, 1961).

3. William Seitz, *Mark Tobey* (New York: Museum of Modern Art, 1962); *Tobey's 80: A Retrospective* (Seattle: Seattle Art Museum, 1971); *A Tribute to Mark Tobey* (Washington, D.C.: National Collection of Fine Arts, Smithsonian Institution, 1974); and Eliza Rathbone, *Mark Tobey: City Paintings* (Washington, D.C.: National Gallery of Art, 1984).

the perfect traveling companion for such a trip; he had been born in Hong Kong and was fascinated with developing art forms that would speak of the unity of East and West. Tobey had become enamored of Chinese calligraphy and art through his friendship with Teng Kuie, a Chinese student he had met in Seattle. Leach and Tobey planned to visit Hong Kong, Shanghai, and Japan. Upon learning of this opportunity, Tobey must immediately have written Shoghi Effendi, who replied:

March 14th, 1934

Dear Bahá'í Friend,

It was such a pleasure for the Guardian to receive your welcome letter and to learn of your projected trip to China. He hopes that your stay in that country will be an opportunity for you to do something for the Cause. In Shanghai we have a small group of believers, among them Mr. Ouskouli, originally a Persian, but who has been living since long in China. He is an old and devoted servant of the Cause. You will also find there a young and enthusiastic Chinese believer by the name of Dr. Tsao who, in addition to his many intellectual gifts, is a wonderful soul, so active and so restless. He has already done some valuable translations into Chinese, among them the "Paris Talks" of the Master and the "Some Answered Questions."[23] Dr. Ouskouli's address is as follows: P.O. Box 551, Shanghai, China. I am sure he will be delighted to introduce you to Dr. Tsao, who, you may be glad to know, is fully conversant with the English language.

In closing please accept Shoghi Effendi's best wishes, and be assured of his prayers for your spiritual advancement and physical welfare,

Yours in His Service,
H. Rabbani

May the Beloved bless your efforts, guide your steps and enable you to promote effectively the best interests of His Faith.

Your true brother,
Shoghi

Tobey's papers do not contain evidence of teaching trips or indicate that he contacted the Bahá'ís of Shanghai, but his firm adherence to the Bahá'í Faith had an important impact on his traveling companion. In his autobiography *Beyond East and West,* Leach wrote of how his friendship with Tobey changed his life:

Mark Tobey was the profoundest influence in my life. It was through him I became a Bahá'í.

I was first introduced to him at Dartington Hall in Devonshire, in 1932. He was the resident artist; I came as a potter. There was an immediate exchange between us. He talked to me about the Bahá'í Faith, sharing with me his books. I was most moved by Nabil's narrative and its immediacy, but it took eight years for me to reach acceptance.[24]

Although Leach reports that the idea of the oneness of all religions was at first too difficult for him to grasp, Tobey's patient teaching sowed the seed which allowed Leach's faith to flower into a mature understanding of the new religion. Destined to become one of the most important potters of the twentieth century, Leach was only one of many who were profoundly influenced by Tobey's teaching.

After the journey with Leach to Hong Kong and Shanghai, Tobey traveled to Japan where he spent a month in a Zen monastery in Kyo-

23. *Paris Talks* is a collection of talks given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá in Paris in 1911 and 1912 (London: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1972). *Some Answered Questions* is a collection of answers to eighty-four questions put to 'Abdu'l-Bahá at table during 1904, 1905, and 1906 (collected and trans. Laura Clifford Barney [Wilmette, Ill.: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1981]).

24. Bernard Leach, "Mark, dear Mark," *World Order* 11.3 (Spring 1977): 28. See also Bernard Leach, *Beyond East and West: Memoirs, Portraits, Essays* (New York: Watson Guptill, 1978) 164–65. Nabil's Narrative is *The Dawn-Breakers,* a detailed and poetic account of the early history of the Bahá'í Faith, by Muḥammad-i-Zarandí, surnamed Nabíl, trans. and ed. by Shoghi Effendi (Wilmette, Ill.: Bahá'í Publishing Trust, 1932).